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**BIOLOGICAL SCIENCES EXPERTS GROUP
Action Request Form**

Background

(U) The National Counterproliferation Center (NCPC) has formed a Biological Sciences Experts Group (BSEG) that will provide advice and counsel on scientific and technical issues relevant to the Intelligence Community's (IC's) mission to counter the threat posed by the proliferation of biological threat agents. The functions of this Expert Group are: (1) to support the IC customers in the design, execution, or interpretation of results of scientific/technical experimental protocols, intelligence analyses, or collection methodologies; (2) to undertake technical assessments or performance review of the IC's scientific or technical experimental protocols, intelligence analyses, or collection methods; and (3) to address other relevant issues needed to counter biological threat agents.

Process

(U//FOUO) Any IC entity may identify a need and then request the assistance of the BSEG by submitting this form. All issues and relevant data must be clearly identified and the scope of the BSEG must be bounded. NCPC's Biological Issue team will oversee the process of prioritizing requests, assigning them to specific BSEG members and receiving feedback from them. For additional information, please contact the Biological Issue Team at DNI-NCPC-Bio.

NOTE: Please remember to classify this document with appropriate project classification.

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**BIOLOGICAL SCIENCES EXPERTS GROUP
Action Request Form (U//FOUO)****Requestor Entity Name/Agency/Office:** CIA/MPH/Global Health Team**POC Name/Title:** [REDACTED] PhD/Global Health Analyst**Contact information:**Secure line: [REDACTED] Unclass line: [REDACTED] ICemail: [REDACTED] @cia.ic.gov**Project Title:** Request for Mutation Frequency of MERS-CoV and Assessment of human passage riskRequest Date: 4 September 2015Project Start Date: As soon as availableProject Due Date: 30 September 2015

Estimated hours of work/BSEG member(s): 8

Approval Status:

Date Approved/Disapproved: _____

Date Completed: _____

Topic/Subject Area:(U) Infectious Diseases and Pandemic Potential

Level of requester involvement: (please check one)

☐ None (send in for complete outside action/review)☒ Minimal (consult when needed)☐ Equal (partner with group on all parts/steps of process)☐ Lead (task out questions/projects for collaborative review sessions)**Abstract: (please limit to 300 words or less):**

(U) Rapid advances in biotechnology demand that the intelligence community (IC) considers their impact in the overall biological threat spectrum. Recently interest has focused on the threat from MERS-CoV. The virus, because of its low human to human transmission, is not considered a pandemic threat. However, the ability of the organism to pass from human to human suggests that there may be mutants that would allow the virus to become more efficient at human to human transfer. The mutants can be generated from point mutation, crossover events, or from co-infection with another coronavirus, however, the rate of the events, and thus their relative risk has not been described well in our community. We ask for a paper outlining the rate of mutation, the number of passages from human to human to lock in these mutations (or to generate them), and the molecular genetic means through which this is likely to occur. Also, an opinion of

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relative risk of these events (likely to unlikely to impossible-nearly impossible) is requested.
Most of the information was presented at a previous BSEG meeting, but a consolidated effort on
this one topic is requested.

Approved by NCPC COTR on 09 Sept 2015.

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